



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

### RECORD RAINS IN SANTA BARBARA

A man puts up emergency tape along a flooded street Monday in Santa Barbara. The city received a record rainfall over the weekend, making a mess, but no serious injuries were reported. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

## 592 jail sex abuse claims, all leading nowhere

Lack of ‘substantiated’ allegations against staff raises red flags about investigations.

By CONNOR SHEETS

There hasn’t been a “substantiated” allegation of sexual abuse by staff against an inmate in the nation’s largest jail system since 2021.

At first glance, the statistic — based on Los Angeles County Sheriff’s Department data — might appear to indicate that a federal law called the Prison Rape Elimination Act has finally accomplished its mission more than two decades after it was enacted by Congress.

But a broad array of local oversight officials and advocacy groups are raising eyebrows over the claim, and bringing new scrutiny to how the Sheriff’s Department investigates allegations of sexual abuse made by inmates against their jailers.

L.A. County incarcerates about 13,000 people — including roughly 1,500 women — throughout its network of jails watched over by sheriff’s deputies.

Sheriff’s Department records show that between January 2022 and September 2025, inmates filed 592 allegations of abuse and harassment against staff. None was deemed “substantiated,” which the Sheriff’s Department defines on its website as “an allegation that was investigated and determined to have occurred.”

The suggestion that there has not been enough evidence to support even one alleged incident by staff against an inmate in nearly four years has struck some tasked with monitoring the Sheriff’s Department as absurd.

“When you have this many complaints and you have zero that are founded, there is something wrong with the process,” said George B. Newhouse, a member of the L.A. County Sheriff Civilian Oversight Commission.

L.A. County’s Office of Inspector General and advocacy groups, including the Anti-Recidivism Coalition and Peace Over Violence, also shared concerns about the lack of substantiated allegations during a Nov. 4 virtual discussion of the federal Prison Rape Elimination Act, or PREA. The law was enacted in 2003 in an effort to reduce sexual abuse behind [See Jails, A7]

## How Trump could try to withhold Epstein files

House lawmakers are expected to unite on a bill to release the investigation documents

By Michael Wilner

WASHINGTON — In political exile at his mansion in Florida, under investigation for possessing highly classified documents, Donald Trump summoned his lawyer in 2022 for a fateful conversation. A folder had been compiled with 38 documents that should have been returned to the federal government. But Trump had other ideas.

Making a plucking motion, Trump suggested his attorney, Evan Corcoran, remove the most incriminating material. “Why don’t you take them with you to your hotel room, and if there’s anything really bad in there, like, you know, pluck it out,” Corcoran memorialized in a series of notes that surfaced during criminal proceedings.

Trump’s purported willingness to conceal evidence from law enforcement

as a private citizen is now fueling concern on Capitol Hill that his efforts to thwart the release of Justice Department files in the Jeffrey Epstein investigation could lead to similar obstructive efforts — this time wielding the powers of the presidency.

Since resuming office in January, Trump has opposed releasing files from the federal investigation into the conduct of his former friend, a convicted sex offender and alleged sex trafficker who is believed to have abused more than 200 women and girls. But bipartisan fervor has only grown over the case, with House lawmakers across party lines expected to unite behind a bill on Tuesday that would compel the release of the documents.

Last week, facing intensifying public [See Epstein, A6]

## Newsom runs alone, for now. Is he vulnerable from the left?

One year from the unofficial launch of the 2028 campaign, the governor is out front with momentum

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Before flying to Brazil last week, showing up for the United States at an international summit skipped by the Trump administration, Gavin Newsom made a stop in Texas. The redistricting fight that started there had just taken a powerful counterpunch thanks to the governor’s action in California. “Don’t poke the bear,” Newsom told an elated crowd of Democrats.

In Washington, a handful of Senate Democrats had just voted with Republicans



BRANDON BELL Getty Images  
**GOV. GAVIN NEWSOM** touts his Proposition 50 victory recently in Texas.

to reopen the government, relenting on a fight for an extension of healthcare tax credits. Newsom lashed out harshly against his party colleagues. “Pathetic,” he wrote online, later telling The Times, “you don’t start something unless you’re going to finish.”

They were just Newsom’s latest moves in an aggressive strategy to shore up early support for an expected run for president starting next year, after the 2026 midterm elections, when both parties will face competitive primaries without an incumbent seeking [See Newsom, A7]

## Economic anxiety is a point of unity in a divided country, survey finds

By THOMAS BEAUMONT, SIMRAN PARWANI AND AMELIA THOMSON-DEVEAUX

DES MOINES — Pessimism about the country’s future has risen in cities since last year, but rural America is more optimistic about what’s ahead for the U.S., according to a new survey from the American Communities Project.

And despite President

Trump’s insistence that crime is out of control in big cities, residents of the nation’s largest metropolitan centers are less likely to list crime and gun violence among the chief concerns facing their communities than they were a couple of years ago.

Optimism about the future also is down from last year in areas with large Latino communities.

These are some of the snapshots from the new

ACP/Ipsos survey, which offers a nuanced look at local concerns by breaking the nation’s counties into community types, using data points such as race, income, age and religious affiliation. The survey evaluated moods and priorities across the 15 community types, such as heavily Latino areas, big cities and different kinds of rural communities.

The common denominator across the communi- [See Future, A10]

## O.J. Simpson’s estate agrees to pay Goldmans

The \$58-million claim stems from a suit the family won in 1997 in Ron Goldman’s death.

By RICHARD WINTON AND HANNAH FRY

Ron Goldman’s family has been fighting for justice for three decades, ever since the man they believed responsible for his murder was found not guilty.

They’ve waged court fights, done painstaking forensic accounting and even some detective work to try to get O.J. Simpson to pay.

But all efforts ended in frustration, as the football legend, who was also found not guilty of killing his ex-wife Nicole Brown Simpson, spent his days on the golf course, served time in prison and wrote a book featuring a hypothetical description of the slayings as if he were the assailant.

Now, Simpson’s estate for the first time has accepted a multimillion-dollar claim from Goldman’s father, Fred Goldman, stemming from a

wrongful death suit the family won against Simpson in 1997.

The Goldmans had collected only a fraction of the \$33-million judgment, which continued to grow because of interest, while Simpson maintained over the decades that he didn’t have the money to pay. But it remains unclear how much the family will actually recover, after accounting for Simpson’s debts on an estate valued at just under \$600,000.

Simpson’s executor, Malcolm LaVergne, indicated in a document filed in Clark County District Court in Nevada on Friday that the estate was approving the nearly \$58-million claim, plus interest. Simpson, 76, died in April 2024 of prostate cancer at his home in Las Vegas.

It marks an important step in the fight that Fred Goldman has waged for 31 years — even if he doesn’t end up with much of the money, said his attorney, Michael Rafferty.

“The executor’s acceptance of the claim is a positive acknowledgment of the debt, which is something [See Simpson, A6]

## A renegade’s vote to end shutdown

Rep. Adam Gray (D-Merced) has his sights on reelection in battleground district.

By ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — Rep. Adam Gray was one of only six House Democrats — and the only one from California — who voted with Republicans in favor of a deal to end the government shutdown, and there was a calculated reason behind that decision.

Gray, a first-term Democrat from the Central Valley, is running for reelection in a majority Latino district that national Republicans are expected to heavily target as they defend their narrow House majority in next fall’s midterm elections. Last year, Gray won his seat by 187 votes, and although redistricting has since made the 13th District more favorable to Democrats, it remains highly competitive.

The Merced Democrat’s vote reflects the political reality of representing one of the nation’s few battle-



ANDREW KUHN Merced Sun-Star

**REP. ADAM GRAY** won his Central Valley seat by 187 votes last year.

ground districts. Gray is positioning himself as an independent-minded Democrat willing to buck leadership on politically divisive issues. The shutdown deal gave him a rare opportunity to put that in practice, even at the risk of frustrating members of his party.

“I know it is not comfortable, and I know there’s people that are going to be mad at me,” Gray told The Times. “But I am not here to win an [See Gray, A5]



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### UC TUITION VOTE

Students are fighting a hike proposal regents are considering because of financial uncertainty. Above, UCLA’s campus. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

### A scolding in the Comey case

A magistrate judge rules that the Justice Department made “profound investigative missteps.” **NATION, A4**

### Weather

A shower or two. L.A. Basin: 63/46. **B6**

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### Rams have that Super Bowl vibe

Latest win shows team is bona fide contender, Dylan Hernández writes. **SPORTS, B10**

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